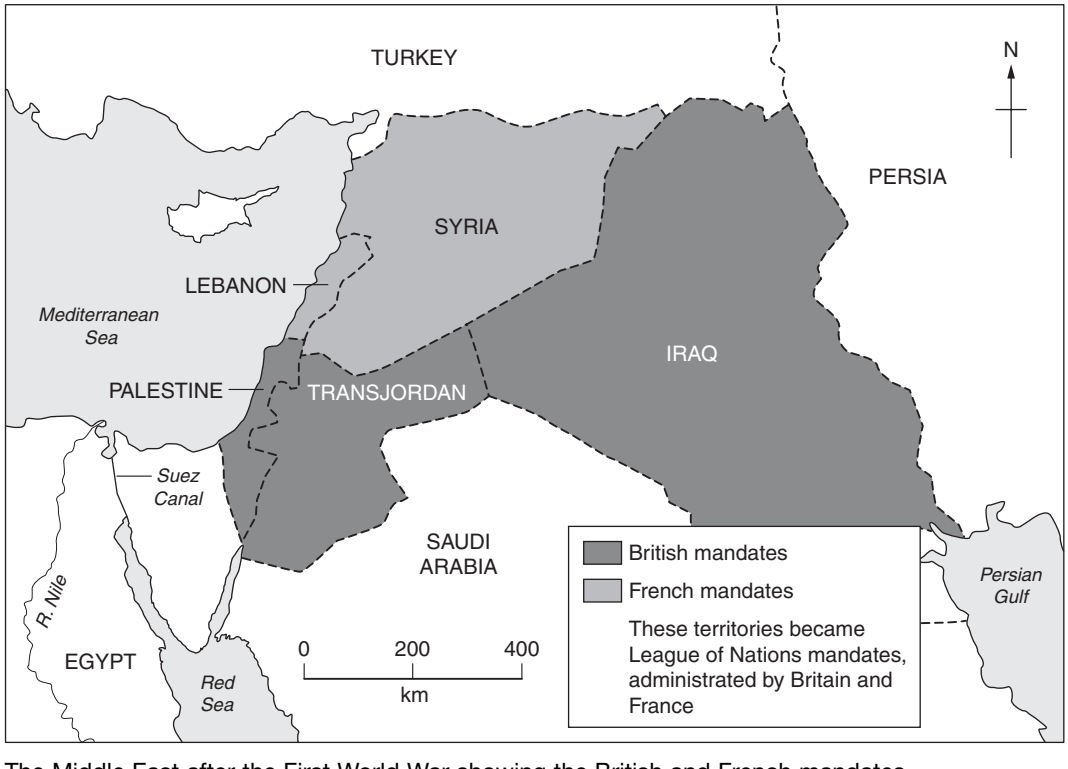
Lawrence ('Lawrence of Arabia') felt that Hussein, the Sharif of Mecca, had been humiliated by the Sykes–Picot Agreement and the subsequent mandates. Hussein was head of the Hashemite family who were descended from the Prophet Muhammad. At the end of the war, Lawrence had advised the British government to establish Hussein's son, Faisal, as King of Syria. However, Syria was a French mandate and the British, now the strongest power in the Middle East, seemed to attach more importance to their alliance with France than their promises to Hussein. In 1921, the British allowed French forces to invade Syria and expel Faisal from the throne he had held for two years.

Instead, the British made Faisal King of Iraq and recognised his older brother, Abdullah, as the ruler of Transjordan. (He became King in 1946.) The two Hashemite princes thus became rulers of the semi-independent Arab states of Iraq and Transjordan, both of which were British mandates. These countries became two of the main pillars of Britain's empire in the Middle East after the First World War.



The Middle East after the First World War showing the British and French mandates.